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The Bhutanese

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LEADING THE WAY

Civil Service attrition rate sees dramatic fall in Jan, Feb and March 2024 compared to 2023

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Massive Hailstone damage to Tsirang's chillies, vegetables and fruits

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Times get much tougher for Bhutanese students in Australia

But there is a determination to stick it out

Perth, Australia

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

In the July 2022 to June 2023 financial year, a record 15,552 Bhutanese got visas to Australia, of which 8,187 were students and 7,365 were dependents, while from July 2023 to February 2024 a total of 8,387 Bhutanese got visas of which 4,054 were students and 4,333 were dependents.

It is these above groups of Bhutanese who recently arrived in Australia that are facing a tough time with only 24 hours per week limited working hours from July 2023 onwards, more expensive housing and difficulty in getting jobs.

This paper talked to two female students in Perth who both requested anonymity, and Dr Sonam Tenzin who is a businessman there.

Drying Jobs

The first student, Pema (name changed), said that it is not easy to get jobs as student are only allowed to work 24 hours per week, and so many mainstream employers do not want to employ them due to the limited hours.

"In the job interview, they ask about our visa condition and the moment we say we are a student they turn us down, saying they are looking for those without such work limitations," said Pema.

Pema said that when they do get jobs it usually pays less and below the minimum wage of AUD 23.33 per hour.

Pema said a cousin sister of hers

cont. on pg 10 & 11

Smugglers use innovative new techniques to smuggle gold via Bhutan

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

The recent incident of three cases of gold smuggling reported at the Paro International Airport, shows Bhutan is being used as an international route by gold smugglers.

Royal Bhutan Police (RBP) said that earlier mostly Indian carriers were involved in the gold smuggling.

However, in the past few days, the trend is shifting, as in the recent case, a Thai national was caught, with the main party

cont. on pg 11

Proposal to give SDF free MICE tourism for 7 days and 6 nights

Earlier 4 night MICE waiver was never implemented

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

Earlier this year in late January the Department of Tourism announced that to promote MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibition) tourism in Bhutan, there will be SDF waiver to MICE participants for 4 nights not including the travel dates to the venues, including the arrival and departure dates.

There was a lot of excitement around this, but it was never implemented as it was found that the Department of Immigration website was not able to incorporate this as its SDF waiver system was only for officials visiting and no proper SOP had been developed.

In short, the policy announcement had come before the system was updated.

Now the Tourism Department wants to go one step further and not only implement it but give 6 nights and 7 days not including the travel dates.

The Department made this proposal as it was thought that 4 nights MICE will not allow for MICE conferences in eastern Bhutan given the time it takes to travel there.

cont. on pg 11

Loan deferral to be more targeted after June 2024

Tenzing Lamsang & Dorji Choden/ *Thimphu*

The loan deferral is coming to an end for various sectors in June 2024 and after this, blanket deferrals of the past is unlikely.

According to a reliable source the Royal Monetary Authority (RMA) is keen to let the banks decide client by client on who can pay or not pay instead of giving sectoral deferrals.

However, a final decision is pending with various sides requesting and petitioning the government, though any final decision will be entirely that of the RMA.

The source said that an important

cont. on pg 05

Editorial

Australia Reality Check

While the numbers have reduced by half this year, still large numbers of Bhutanese are heading to Australia.

This is not even taking into account Canada and other destination.

The first reality check should be for young Bhutanese aiming to build a life in Australia.

Thanks to the various visa and work hour restrictions, Australia is rapidly turning into an unsustainable destination with limited working hours, strict monitoring, high rentals and high cost of living.

Youths are unable to find jobs for months and even when they find one it does not pay well.

The students can barely manage to pay their fees thanks to their partners there otherwise they say it is next to impossible for a lone student.

Apart from Australia even Canada and UK is tightening its visa rules making it even more difficult than Australia.

The booming post pandemic times are over and all these countries wants the excessive numbers of students to head back as their own people are disgruntled with the high rentals and cost of living.

New destinations are being touted but each has its own drawback. For example, Germany appears to the next big destination but students should know that if you do not know German then your prospects of earning are not very good.

The second reality check is for us back home.

It is becoming increasingly clear that the majority of Bhutanese in Australia are either not coming back or not coming back anytime soon.

Even if visa conditions tighten up there they can go for courses and jobs that will enable longer stay or they can simply apply for other countries.

The majority will not come back because while their hearts are here they have no jobs and economic activities to come back to.

The trend of global migrations also proves this.

Instead the Australia group are starting to sell their properties in Bhutan, will transmit their money and savings to Australia and also take their children, parents and relatives over time.

Instead the lower qualified and paid middle east group will remit more faithfully in the long run and even come back with skills.

Q

Just a quote

"- What do you want to be when you grow up?, asked a Macedonian father his child. -A foreign citizen."

Ljupka Cvetanova

DRUKYUL SPEAKS ITS MIND

Understanding mental health issues and stigma in Bhutan

By Monica Rai

A deep-seated issue that remains shrouded in silence is mental health. As the world grapples with the complexities of psychological well-being, many in Bhutan, too, find themselves at a crossroads, where understanding and stigma intersect in the narratives of the people.

Tshering Yangzom, a resident of Tsirang, reflects on her personal encounter with mental health within her family.

She said "Our family dynamic has become tense and more circumspect, as a result of my brother's occasional emotional outbursts, which are a sharp contrast to his typical behaviour. He had never behaved like that before; it was during his outburst last year that he was willing to hit and fight anyone. We sobbed and consoled him for hours as a result."

She said that despite the turmoil, the family refrained from seeking professional help, a decision influenced by a lack of awareness and accessible resources in their village.

She said, "I think there is a sheer lack of awareness and understanding of mental health in remote parts, despite living in the 21st century, and our family had no clue to whom to contact during the turmoil we went through last year."

Ten Dorji, a resident of Thimphu, said, "In our country, mental health issues are prevalent, particularly in urban areas. From my interactions, I have observed that factors, such as financial strain, fractured family dynamics, and intense work pressures contribute significantly. Moreover, alongside the challenges of mental health, itself, there exists a pervasive stigma surrounding individuals who are diagnosed with it."

"People often overlook those with mental illness, dismissing their behaviours as simply "difficult" or "eccentric." There's a tendency to isolate and label individuals who withdraw from social interactions or express unconventional opinions as "crazy" or "unstable." Which is very wrong," he added.

He said that once one is diagnosed with a mental illness, it becomes difficult for people to put trust in them.

Dema Lhamo, a recent college graduate, also shared her perspective on the stigma surrounding mental illness.

She said, "There is a pervasive misconception that individuals with mental illness cannot be effectively treated, a belief that unfortunately infuses our society. In Bhutan, mental illness is often referred to as "Sem Pham ghi Nyezhi," associating it with the soul and suggesting a sense of weakness or psychological instability."

She said, "This stigma can discourage individuals from seeking help, as being labelled as mentally unstable may lead to social isolation. I had a schoolmate who used to struggle with mental health issues due to her stepfather harassing her. I told her that we should take this issue to our school's counsellor before anything bad happens to her; however, without her courage, we couldn't do anything."

"Now that I think of it, I think I shouldn't have let it slide easily, but I could have forced her every day to talk with the school counsellor and immediately to the police," she added.

Dema Lhamo said that she does not know what has happened to her friend or her whereabouts after high school.

Dorji Lhendup, a high school graduate, shared similar sentiments.

He said, "Despite witnessing individuals grappling with psychological distress, I could not do anything as I was hesitant to intervene. Due to societal taboos, such as personality in schools, most people don't view mental illness as a disease; instead, they believe it is something that people do to get attention. Additionally, people believe that emotional instability is a contributing factor to mental illness, so I feared what if the other person would not like it."

Kezang Dechen, another high schooler, said that the societal attitudes towards mental illness include ostracization and neglect faced by those seeking help. Which is true for those who were closely associated with the one who sought help.

25-year-old Priya is one of them, as she shares her harrowing experience navigating her nephew's chronic anxiety disorder, which reveals the painful reality of denial and resistance within families.

She said, "My nephew has been quiet ever since I have known him, all of us thought he just did not like talking too much, and we let him be, but at the beginning of this year, he did not want to go to school and was always cooped up in his room, which made me worry after a repeated pattern for weeks."

"When I inquired about it consistently, I found out he could not face people, did not like meeting them or talking with them, and at the end, did not like doing anything at all. It was then that I made the decision to take him to a counsellor; it was then that he was diagnosed with chronic anxiety disorder," she added.

She said that she made it a point to inform her family members about the diagnosis. To her astonishment, nobody could believe it was true; they were all in complete shock.

Another sister also talked about her experience.

"Rehab facilities and mental health wards are stigmatized. My brother's need to be taken to a rehabilitation facility for treatment had my father in denial and in mourning. More than his son's health and well-being, his reputation was his first concern," she said.

"I was completely taken aback by my father's behaviour, but I realised that everyone reacts this way in our country, so I decided to forgive him, and look after my brother while he was receiving assistance," she said.

She said that it should not have been the case, and now there are worries about the denial of the family members becoming the new normal when their child or a relative seeks help due to their mental illness.

Ten Dorji also emphasised the urgent need for Bhutan to prioritise mental health advocacy programs and improve counselling facilities, including the establishment of a dedicated psychiatric hospital to ensure comprehensive treatment options for individuals in need.

Furthermore, the investigation revealed a widespread lack of understanding regarding mental health issues among the people. Even among those who were aware, there was a prevailing reluctance to seek assistance when needed, driven by the fear of societal judgement and stigma.

Civil Service attrition rate sees dramatic fall in Jan, Feb and March 2024 compared to 2023

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

The combination of a higher pay hike, and tougher immigration rules in Australia, seems to have worked its magic on the civil service, as the attrition rate has gone down significantly in the first three months of 2024 compared to 2023.

A total of 524 civil servants have separated from the civil service in these three months, with 424 being due to voluntary resignation, 75 contract completions, 10 deaths, 3 terminations, 3 compulsory retirement, 8 cancellations or withdrawal and 1 wrong employment ID (ID given twice).

This is compared to 1,870 civil servants who separated from the service in January, February and March 2023 with 1,182 being voluntary resignations.

In January 2024, a total of 264 separated from the service of which 194 were voluntary resignations.

In January 2023, it was 582 that separated from the service with 446 voluntary resignations.

In February 2024, a total of 143 separated from the service of which 124 were voluntary resignations.

In February 2023, it was 937 that separated from the service with 429 voluntary resignations.

In March 2024, a total of 117 separated from the service of which 106 were voluntary resignations.

In March 2023, it was 350 that separated from the service with 307 voluntary resignations.

If one looks at the 424 that voluntarily left in January, February and March 2024 the biggest professional group leaving is in the teaching category with 150 teachers, 8 ECCD facilitators, 2 Vice Principals, 4 child caregivers, 4 matrons, 6 wardens, and in the tertiary sector, it is 1 cluster lead teacher, 4 instructors, 2 assistant lecturers and 1 associate lecturer.

The next biggest group voluntarily resigning is in the medical field, with 31 nurses, 1 doctor, 3 people from the dental section, 2 ophthalmic technicians, 2 OT technicians, 1 ortho technician, 1 pharmacist, 2 pharmacy technicians, 2 laboratory technicians, 8 laboratory assistants, 1 laboratory officer, 1 medical officer, and 7 health assistants.

The third biggest group leaving is 22 engineers followed by 16 administration assistants, 11 foresters, 9 from revenue services, 9 accounts assistants, 9 gewog adm officers, 7 program officers, 7 from agriculture and livestock services, 6 audit officers, 6 drivers, 5 immigration officers, 5 from legal services, etc.

However, while the 2024 drop is a positive development, the large numbers of civil servants leaving is still an issue.

While 524 civil servants separated from the service in the first three months of 2024, however, there were 476 civil servants separated in the first three months in 2022, 468 in 2021 and 393 in 2020.

This is concerning as the 524 numbers, while much lower than the peak of 2023 still means that key people, like nurses, technicians, engineers, teachers etc., are being lost.

Bhutan lost 5,202 civil servants in 2023 of which 3,728 were voluntary resignations.

This is compared to 2,646 separations in 2022 with 1,686 voluntary resignations, 1,504 separations in 2021 with 939 voluntary resignations and 1,084 separations in 2020 with 570 voluntary resignations, 1,614 separations in 2019 with 579 voluntary resignations, 925 separations in 2018, 782 separations in 2017, 656 separations in 2016, 472 separations in 2015 and 442 separations in 2014.

The data clearly shows that resignations shot up from 2016 onwards, which was also the start of the Australia rush of sorts, that went up strongly in the post pandemic phase and reached a peak in 2023.

Ranking system forces lowest ranked students to go for Arts in high school but with no scope beyond it

Sonam Tshomo Tshering/ *Thimphu*

In the academic year 2024, all the students who were awarded pass certificates in Bhutan Certificates of Secondary Education (BCSE), 2023 were eligible for admission to the Government Higher Secondary Schools. 10, 636 seats were available in government higher secondary schools.

However, all the students with pass certificates are not eligible to take the Science stream in class 11 as there is a certain mark each student should get in the examination. Students opting to study Science should have a minimum of 45% in Mathematics and 55% percent in Science (average of Biology, Chemistry, and Physics) with a minimum of 51% each in Biology, Chemistry, and Physics.

For the students to study Commerce, they should obtain a minimum of 40% marks in Mathematics in class 10 and all the students with pass certificates awarded are qualified to study Arts.

Regardless of the lack of Arts courses in the colleges and limited opportunities in the future, the students with lower grades are left with the only option to opt for Arts in classes 11 and 12.

Due to the intake capacity of some of the schools, there aren't enough seats available for all the students in the other streams, therefore, even though some of the students are eligible for streams other than Arts, especially Commerce, they are left with the only option to enroll in the Arts stream.

However, that doesn't apply to all the schools and the choices are given to them if they have the required marks.

This restricted choice leaves students feeling disheartened and uncertain about their future. With few Arts courses available in colleges and limited job opportunities in fields traditionally associated with the Arts, these students face a challenging road ahead. The lack of options not only limits their academic growth, but also restricts their ability to explore their interests and talents fully.

As they progress through classes 11 and 12, they struggle with issues related to their identity, goals, and the justice of a system that seems to set them up for success based only on their academic standing.

According to the Chief Education Officer of Dagana, there are four higher secondary schools in the Dagana, and out of four, three schools offer the Arts stream. Additionally, it is also mentioned that merit-based admission determines the choice of the stream, and so those with lower ranks are classified as Arts.

The Principal of Jakar Higher Secondary School said, "Students who are taking Arts in class 11 from Bumthang and Trongsa are all in Jakar Higher Secondary School this year, and there is a total of 18 students which is barely comparable to the total number of students in a section."

As in Gasa, the only higher secondary school is Bjishong Higher Secondary School, and there are only 19 Arts students enrolled in class 11.

The main reason why students are reluctant to take the Arts stream is due to the limited courses in the colleges for the Arts students, and there are a few students who are genuinely interested to learn the subjects associated with the Arts stream.

All the Arts students in class 11 from Wangduephodrang are in Phobjikha Central School this year. Some of the students out there did not qualify for the Commerce and Science streams, so their only option was to study Arts.

However, some of them were obligated to take the Arts stream due lack of seats for the Commerce stream.

There are four higher secondary schools in Mongar, and the Chief Education Officer said, "There are Arts students in class 11 in all the schools in Mongar, and there are around 25 to 35 students in each school."

In the Gelephu Higher Secondary School, there are 28 students taking Arts in class 11. Their reason for taking Arts stream is nothing different from the students who took Arts in other schools.

The Chief Education Officer of Trashigang brought up that there is a section of class 11 Arts students in all 5 higher secondary schools in Trashigang, and there are two sections in Khaling school which is surprisingly unique from current circumstances.

Department of School Education mentioned that the grading system has been put in place with good intentions. Not only that, the cut-off marks for the students are also minimal.

The rise of young entrepreneurs across the country

Dorji Choden/ *Thimphu*

The youth across the country are seizing the opportunity to pioneer projects that not only promise financial gain but also secure future employment prospects.

A group of students from Gyalposhing College of Information Technology (GCIT) has unveiled Xceed Studio, a creative powerhouse aimed at pushing the boundaries of innovation.

"We aim to expand the horizons of creativity and innovation, prioritizing the delivery of exceptional user experiences through visually captivating designs across all our offerings. Our overarching goal is to establish ourselves as a premier creative studio, setting new benchmarks within the industry. With a steadfast dedication to excellence, we are committed to charting a fresh course for the creative sector, redefining standards and inspiring others along the way."

Another group of second-year students of GCIT has come up with project named Bright Vision to redefine visual communication and storytelling.

"Our company is dedicated to revolutionizing the landscape of visual communication by offering distinctive solutions tailored to meet the diverse needs of contemporary businesses and individuals," shares the team.

Their core objectives include providing innovative solutions encompassing graphic design, photography, videography, and advertising videos.

GCIT has several other projects by the students such as No Mind Bhutan, Web Dynamo, Enkirealm, Novus Solution, DigiOps and Anup.

Meanwhile, Yeshi Jamtsho and Sudharshan Adhikari from Sherubtse College, have introduced 3D Experience, a venture offering accessible 3D printing products and services.

They shared, "We're passionate about using technology to improve accessibility and efficiency. With 3D printing, we've experienced the joy of creativity and innovation firsthand. Our mission is to make this technology more accessible through our services, aiming to serve and inspire all tech enthusiasts beyond traditional institutions in Bhutan."

Similarly, Karma Gyeltshen, a 21-year-old student at Sherubtse College, has founded Tshengyel Studio, driven by a fascination with graphic design and multimedia sparked by captivating YouTube tutorials. Despite initial resource constraints, Tshengyel Studio aims to revolutionize the industry through innovation and collaboration.

Damcho Dorji, a third-year student at Sherubtse College, has launched Shercolconnect, a multimedia hub catering to the burgeoning demand for multimedia tasks and freelancers' needs within the college community. With a team of dedicated members, Shercolconnect is poised to carve a niche in the multimedia landscape.

Meanwhile, Karma Tenzin, a student at Gedu College of Business, has initiated Zhaychhop, a project focused on promoting Bhutanese delicacies worldwide through instant formats.

"ZhayChhop is a business promoting Bhutanese delicacies worldwide in instant formats, starting with Bathup. Our aim is to reduce food waste, empower women, and offer healthy options using local ingredients. Inspired by the lack of local instant food choices, we're filling this gap with authentic Bhutanese flavors," Karma said.

The project is at the prototyping stage, and currently experimenting with a variety of flavors to blend traditional tastes with enticing profiles, appealing to people of all ages.

Tashi Dhendup studying Diploma in Materials and Procurement Management at the Jigme Namgyal Engineering College (JNEC), is running a e-Printing service for the students and staff at a reasonable price.

Rohit Rai, a recent graduate of JNEC, is currently engaged in data collection and entry for his educational platform, younten.bt. Similarly, Ratna Kumari, a graduate with a diploma in Electrical Engineering, clinched first place in a business idea pitching competition two years ago.

The major challenge the students face is the budget constraints and time management. They manage time to work as well as manage their academics, however, the youth are very passionate about their projects and looking forward to grow as they graduate.

These ventures represent a new wave of entrepreneurship in the country, driven by passion, innovation, and a desire to make a meaningful impact on society. As they continue to evolve and grow, they are poised to leave a lasting legacy on the country's business landscape.

Public debt estimated to soar to Nu 306 bn according to Ministry of Finance

Dorji Choden/ *Thimphu*

As per the Macroeconomic Second Quarter Report by the Ministry of Finance (MoF) projections indicate a substantial rise in public debt for the fiscal year 2023-24.

According to the latest data released, the total public debt is estimated to soar to Nu 306.128 billion (bn) representing 114.7 percent of the country's GDP.

The figures underscore a complex interplay of factors driving this surge. Notably, the increase in domestic debt by Nu 985.9 mn aims to address the pressing financing gap, indicating the government's commitment to bolstering domestic resources for developmental initiatives.

However, the most significant spike is observed in external debt, projected to escalate by Nu 28.165 bn. This surge is primarily attributed to disbursements earmarked for critical infrastructure projects, including the Punatsangchhu-I (PHPA-I) and Punatsangchhu-II (PHPA-II) hydropower ventures, alongside investments in small hydropower projects and external budgetary borrowings.

According to the Asian Development Bank (ADB), Bhutan's significant current account deficit has resulted in a 20 percent decrease in foreign exchange reserves. This decline is particularly concerning, as the majority of our imports are denominated in Indian Rupee (INR), and any reduction in earnings from hydropower exports exacerbates the issue.

In 2023, the country saw a modest decrease in public external debt by 2.9 percentage points, amounting to 101.9 percent of GDP. Notably, hydropower debt constituted 66.3 percent of this total. A significant portion of the public external debt, approximately 64.3 percent, was owed to India, with hydro debt accounting for 93.8 percent of this sum. These hydro debts are considered self-liquidating owing to a long-term power purchasing agreement with India.

The MoF's report sheds light on the strategic importance of these investments in driving Bhutan's economic growth and energy security. The PHPA projects, in particular, hold immense potential to harness Bhutan's abundant hydropower resources, thereby contributing to regional energy stability and revenue generation.

However, concerns linger regarding the sustainability of the escalating debt burden, especially in the context of the country's GDP ratio. While infrastructure investments are imperative for unlocking development potential, prudent debt management strategies become indispensable to mitigate associated risks and ensure fiscal resilience.

His Majesty The King conferred Red Scarf to Karma Hamu Dorjee, Chairperson of the Royal Civil Service Commission on 10th April 2024

cont. from pg 01

Loan deferral to be more targeted after June 2024

indicator to be looked at is the economic recovery as just another blanket deferral will just be artificially insulating lenders as the economy rebounds.

The source said that some sectors can rebound like for example housing.

There was once a fear that the exodus would lead to low occupancy when new units are being constructed, but that has not been seen said the source.

The source said that banks can individually sit with the client and discuss. For example, a certain house may be doing well but another is not doing well.

Certain considerations can be made like for example the automobile dealers who may have taken loans but are unable to pay right now due to the vehicle import ban.

The source said that when it comes to tourism the data shows that tourism is rebounding back.

A problem of repeated deferrals for the financial institutions is that they are losing track of their clients because when the banks call the clients they get upset and say they are on deferral Kidu and so the bank should not contact them.

The macro assessment of the economy shows it is rebounding back and so there is a reluctance to give the same level of deferrals as in the past.

The source said it will be important to test the waters.

The Finance Minister Lekey Dorji said, "Loan deferral ends by June. The government is discussing with RMA on how best to carry this forward."

The BCCI President Tandy Wangchuk said, "We're going to put in a proposal to the government on the loan deferment issue. We've talked with the private sector and they've shared their concern on the issue."

The Chairman of the Hotel and Restaurant Association of Bhutan, Jigme has already said that most of the hotels are not in a condition to pay and those who pay should be given some incentive.

A question whose answer is not known now is how the Nu 15 bn Economic Stimulus Plan will play out when it comes to loan deferments.

The PDP Manifesto when it comes to ESP had said amongst others, ESP will be used in the Banking sector to inject liquidity, enable loan deferments, reduce interest rates, create other loan scheme to boost the economy.

It would be used to set up special loan schemes to support special groups such as farmers, women, youth, persons with disabilities. There would also be special investments for economic growth of the Rural areas and creation of a specialized credit window dedicated for the CSIs.

When it comes to loan deferment the first monetary measures which started from April 2020 gave a three-month loan deferment till June end 2020.

The second phase monetary measures from the end of June 2020 gave loan deferment till June 2021.

The third phase monetary measures pushed the deferment to June 2022 and the fourth phase monetary measures till June 2023 for low and moderate risk sectors and June 2024 for the high-risk sectors.

High risk sectors were tourism hotels and restaurants, airlines, tour operators and ticketing agents.

The moderate risk category are Construction, Entertainment and recreational services, mining and quarrying, handicrafts and textiles, manufacturing, retail trade, housing (commercial), home loans, consumer loan, mortgage loan, transport, education loan.

The last changein 2023 pushed the low and moderate risk sectors deferment to June 2024 too, but with strict conditions.

In March 2023 RMA provided special consideration for extension of the loan deferment (full or partial) for sectors under the low and moderate risk category till June 2024.

In 2023 RMA said borrowers are required to submit a request for deferment to financial service providers in the Form prescribed by the FIs. The FIs were to carry out detailed assessment of the borrowers requiring loan deferment based on the assessment criteria developed by FIs.

The assessment criteria for corporate borrowers had to include information on latest audited financial statements and cash flow statement to see the performance of the company.

For individual borrowers, the FIs were to review the impact of the pandemic on their employment and source of income.

The impact of tourist numbers on the industry

Dechen Wangmo / *Thimphu*

Between January and March, Bhutan welcomed 25,003 tourists, marking a significant increase compared to the previous year. Although January and February showed little contrast, however, there was a noticeable increase in March, with many more guests arrivals.

Ugyen Chodra, employed at Zhidhay Tours and Treks, noted a slight improvement in sales, though not to pre-pandemic levels. He mentioned their focus on business-to-business operations. However, due to the pandemic, they were unable to participate in travel fairs, leading to a significant decrease in business flow. Post-pandemic, sales have not returned to previous levels, merely providing enough revenue to sustain and manage office operations.

Sonam Thinley, who owns Tower Cafe, mentioned that there has been more tourist activity this year, and they anticipate even more guests visiting the country.

He said his goal is to uphold quality services and food while maintaining cleanliness in the surroundings, benefiting everyone involved. He believes that these aspects are crucial to attract tourists.

Additionally, he said, "I believe there has been a significant increase in tourist numbers compared to last year, but the flow of tourists isn't as overwhelming as it was before the COVID-19 pandemic. Consequently, we haven't encountered any staffing or supply chain challenges at the moment. With many locals relocating, tourism is helping to bridge the gap between supply and demand in the market."

Bhakti Maya, serving as the Room Division Manager at The Willows Hotel, mentioned that during the off-season, their hotel receives around 60 percent of guests, whereas during the tourist season, the numbers increase to 80-90 percent.

"We provide live music and entertaining activities, like bonfires for our guests. We do, however, recognize that some elderly visitors might prefer quieter environments. We ask them about their preferences before involving them in these kinds of activities, and if they would rather be entertained in a quieter environment, we don't include them in these kinds of activities,"she added.

A taxi driver from Mongar, who worked as a driver for five years in Thimphu, mentioned that tourists visiting our country have numerous opportunities available to them,such as collaborating with travel agencies for various activities or services.

"Most tourists tend to visit popular attractions, like Buddha Point, the Memorial Chorten, and the Dzongs in Thimphu. As a driver, we assist them in reaching their desired destinations, and as guides, we also provide recommendations and information about these places," he said.

Trongsa Tashi Ninjey Hotel mentioned that despite an increase in tourist arrivals in the country, areas like Trongsa, Bumthang, and other southern and eastern regions receive fewer visitors compared to western districts, primarily due to SDF.

Tourists have to pay SDF of USD 100 per night, which is higher than the USD 65 SDF they had to pay last year. As a result, there are fewer tourists visiting because of the increased SDF.

"I believe that a USD 100 Sustainable Development Fee is too burdensome for international tourists visiting the Eastern and Central regions of the country. It would be beneficial if the government maintained the SDF at its previous level for tourists visiting these areas. This adjustment could lead to an increase in occupancy rates over time," Hotel and Restaurant Association of Bhutan (HRAB) Chairman, Jigme said.

Jigme, said "There is a need for ongoing efforts focused on growth and recovery within the hospitality sector. It emphasizes the necessity of adapting to changes as needed, maintaining marketing efforts, and collaborating with various stakeholders, including the government, to reach our target of 300,000 at the end of the year," Jigme said.

According to HRAB, there are difficulties around the southern borders, as travelers are choosing to stay on the other side of the border because it offers them with more affordable accommodation choices and exemptions from the Sustainable Development Fee (SDF).

DRUK GREEN POWER CORPORATION LIMITED

TALA HYDROPOWER PLANT
RINCHENTSE, TALA. BHUTAN

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (INTERNATIONAL/DOMESTIC COMPETITIVE BIDDING)

Tala Hydropower Plant, Druk Green Power Corporation Limited invites sealed Bids from eligible Bhutanese Bidders fulfilling the eligibility criteria specified herein and in the tender document for the below mentioned works:

Tender No.& Date	Name of Works	Bid Security (Nu./INR.)	Contract Period	Date of Tender available	Last Date & Time for Bid Submission	Date & Time for Bid Opening
THP0014/2024 08.04.2024	Design, Supply, Installation, testing and Commissioning of 5KLD Sewage Treatment Plant with Sequencing Batch Reactor Technology	200,000.00	6 months	09.04.2024. to 30.04.2024	30.04.2024 at 13:00 Hrs. (BST)	30.04.2024 at 14:30 Hrs. (BST)

Detailed NIT and Bidding Documents are available at DGPC website (www.drukgreen.bt) and can be downloaded from the website free of cost during the period.

Interim Head & Contract & Procurement Division
Tala Hydropower plant

DRUK GREEN POWER CORPORATION LIMITED

NIT No.: **CO0016/2024**

ABRIDGED NOTICE INVITING TENDER (DOMESTIC COMPETITIVE BIDDING)

FOR

SUPPLY, INSTALLATION, CONFIGURATION, TESTING AND COMMISSIONING OF ACTIVE DIRECTORY SERVERS

Druk Green Power Corporation Limited (DGPC) invites sealed bids from eligible bidders for "Supply, Installation, Configuration, Testing and Commissioning of the Active Directory (AD) Servers"

Bidding documents shall be available from **April 12, 2024** to **May 3, 2024**. Bids shall be received on or before **May 3, 2024** up to **1500 Hrs** and shall be opened on the same day at **1530 Hrs**.

Detailed NIT and bidding documents are available at DGPC website (**www.drukgreen.bt**) and can be downloaded free of cost during the period.

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ROYAL UNIVERSITY OF BHUTAN

GEDU COLLEGE OF BUSINESS STUDIES
GEDU: CHHUKHA DZONGKHAG

Ref. (02) ADM/HR/2023-2024**/1111**

VACANCY ANNOUNCEMENT

Gedu College of Business Studies, Royal University of Bhutan is pleased to announce the following vacancies for immediate recruitment.

SL	Position Title	Position Level	Slot (s)	Status
1	Assistant ICT Officer/ICT Officer	8/7	1	Regular
2	Assistant Librarian	8	1	Regular
3	Store Keeper	13	1	Regular
4	Security Guard	GSS	1	Contract

For more detailed information, please log on to college website **www.gcbs.edu.bt**

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Sudoku

				5	
	5	2		6	
1	4	3			5
					3
		1	2		
	3	4			

Difficult rating: ***

answer next issue

Last issue Answers

4	1	3	5	2	6
6	5	2	4	3	1
3	2	1	6	4	5
5	6	4	3	1	2
1	4	6	2	5	3
2	3	5	1	6	4

WEATHER

SATURDAY

Thimphu
Max: 14°C
Min: 02 °C

Trashigang
Max: 23 °C
Min: 16 °C

Trongsa
Max: 15 °C
Min: 08 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 37 °C
Min: 21 °C

SUNDAY

Thimphu
Max: 15 °C
Min: 04 °C

Trashigang
Max: 27 °C
Min: 15 °C

Trongsa
Max: 18 °C
Min: 07 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 37 °C
Min: 22 °C

Source: https://www.accuweather.com/en/bt/bhutan-weather

ZAKAR

SATURDAY

Good day *to make annual and scheduled calendar offerings only.*

Bad day *to consecrate, appease local deities, appoint to new post, start education, shift house, start house construction, hold good discussion, marry, start new business, sell property, hand and take over office, astrological predictions and divinations for both dead and living.*

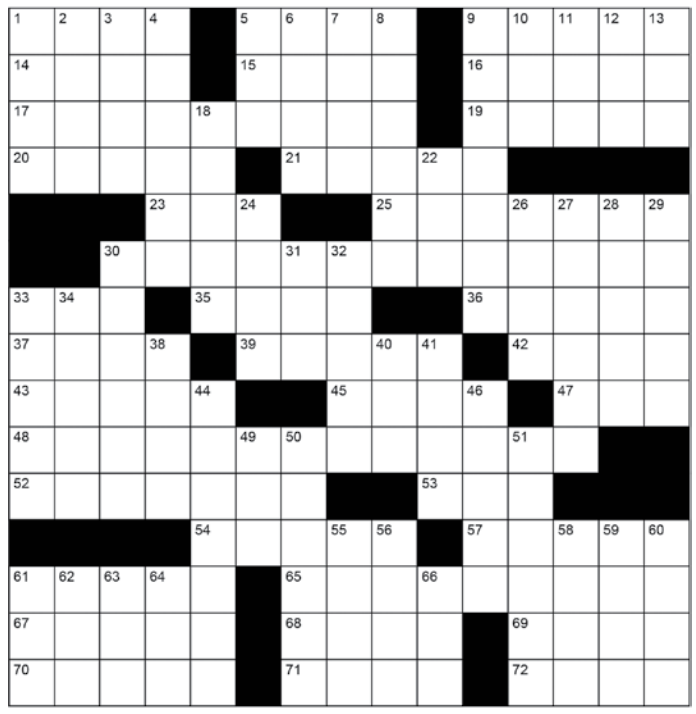
SUNDAY

Good day *to make annual and scheduled calender offerings only.*

Bad day *to consecrate, appease local deities, roof house, appoint to new post, celebrate, marry, shift house, start education, hold good discussion, start new business, hoist Lungdhar and enter new house.*

Source: Dratshang Lhentshog

Crossword puzzles



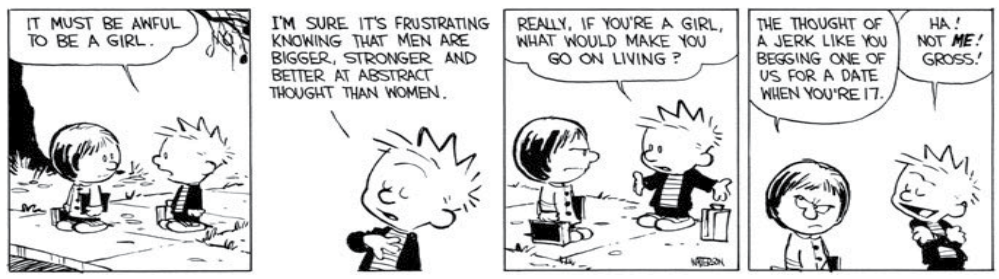
Across

1. Pooh ___ (certain officials)
5. ___ no good
9. Roll into a ball
14. "Leaving on ____ Plane"
15. Controversy
16. Marry in a hurry
17. Most limited in scope
19. Choose for office
20. Pollo partner
21. "Ain't That ___ in the Head?" (Dean Martin song)
23. Apply with a light touch
25. Sea-ruling Titan
30. Tiny babe
33. "Dude!"
35. Here, to Jesus
36. "The Many Loves of ____ Gillis"
37. Alfred, ___ Tennyson
39. Sounds of relief
42. Luminescence
43. Jingle writer, perhaps
45. Omelette ingredient
47. Folks
48. Hopelessly
52. Biblical sage
53. UAL competitor
54. Start of Tony Bennett's signature song
57. Bad deeds
61. Camp David Accords signer
65. Drowsy
67. Common biography subtitle
68. Deck hands
69. ____ Valley, Calif.
70. Bored
71. Library refs., to a Brit
72. Managed care grps.

Down

1. "Hulk" star Eric
2. Cracked a bit
3. Frau's mate
4. Walked with purpose
5. Cesar Chavez's org.
6. Emotional request
7. Chore
8. Sunroof, say
9. Good time for a getaway
10. "___ That Jazz"
11. Pseudonymous surname
12. Checkout bars?
13. Caress
18. Seiji of the symphony
22. 201, to Caesar
24. Summer get-togethers, briefly
26. In ____ (addled)
27. West Bank city
28. Marriage
29. Agonizes (over)
30. Common
31. Opposite of non
32. Severity
33. Emotional doldrums
34. Word with Drive or clown
38. Pedestal part
40. Small chuckle
41. Pleads
44. Convention VIP
46. Less numerous
49. Encyclopedia abbr.
50. "Romanian Rhapsodies" composer Georges
51. Hardly spare
55. Golfer's alert
56. Decorated a yard with tissue streamers
58. "____ Not in Love" Faith Hill tune
59. Prom night transportation
60. Biol. and bot.
61. Half of a large African tree
62. Pipe joint
63. Role for Angelina
64. Hypotheticals
66. Pained cries

calvin & hobbes



garfield

HEADQUARTERS ROYAL BHUTAN ARMY LUNGTENPHU

ANNOUNCEMENT OF VACANCY

1. Royal Bhutan Army is pleased to announce the availability of 200 Male and 100 female vacancies for recruitment into RBA for 80th Batch Male Recruits and 4th Batch Female Recruits.

2. Interested candidates should report to the following Recruitment Centers for preliminary selection. The details of the Recruitment Centre's, Catchment Areas, Time plan (reporting time) and contact person is tabulated as under:-

S/No	Recruitment Centre	Catchment Areas	Date of Selection	Focal Officer Contact #
1	Trongsa (Tendrelthang)	Trongsa,Zhemgang & Bumthang	24 & 25 April 2024	**Col Nima Wangdi 17606751**
2	Trashigang, T/gang MSS	Trashigang & Trashiyangtse	27 & 28 Apr 2024	
3	Monger(Retd Armed Force Guest House)	Monger & Lhuentse	30 Apr & 01 May 2024	
4	Wing 12 Wangdue	Gasa, Punakha, Wangdue, Tsirang, & Dagana Dzongkhag	25 & 26 Apr 2024	**Col Sonam Yoezer 77257845**
5	Wg 7, Army Helipad Parking,AHQ	South & Centre Thimphu	29 Apr & 30 Apr 2024	**Col Kezang Dorji 17628483/17378385**
	RBG, Offr"s Mess Parking, RBG Dechencholing	North Thimphu		**Col Pema Wangchuk 17140481**
6	Cdo Wg, Paro	Paro, Haa & Chukha Dzongkhag	25 & 26 Apr 2024	**Col Sonam Gyeltshen 17614330**
7	Wing 8, Samtse	Samtse Dzongkhag & Sombaykha Dungkhag	25 & 26 Apr 2024	**Lt Col Kezang Namgyel 17648694**
8	Wing 2, Wangdigatshel	Phuentsholing & Lhamoizingkha Dungkhag	29 & 30 Apr 2024	**Col karma Lodey Samphel 17601085**
9	Wing 9, Gelephu	Sarbang Dzongkhag & South Tsirang Dzongkhag	27 & 28 Apr 2024	**Col Pelchen Dorji 17626653**
10	Wing 10 , Dewathang	Samdrupjongkhar, Pemagatshel, Trashigang Dzongkhag & Wamrong Dungkhag	29 to 30 Apr 2024	**Maj Sonam Dorji 17885565**
11	9(I)Coy, Jomotshangkha	Jomotshangkha Dungkhag	27 & 28 Apr 2024	**Lt Col Sangay Wangchuk 77777705**

Note : Candidates can register in any of the Recruitment Centre's based on their convenience

3. These Recruitment Centres will escort the selected candidates to Military Training Centre on **07 & 08 May 2024**/own arrangement.
4. Final selection and medical test at Military Training Centre will be carried out with effect from **09 to 11 may 2024.**
5. Qualitative Requirement and Procedures:-

(a) **For Male:-**

(i) Age : Minimum 18 Maximum 25 years.
(ii) Height : Minimum 5 feet 5 inches
(iii) Weight : As per BMI
(iv) Education qualification : Open
(v) No prominent unnatural marks (tattoo of any kind) on any parts of the body that will have to be exposed when in uniform.
(Vi) No body piercing on any part of the body
(Vii) No knock-knee
(viii) No hearing impairment.
(ix) Visual acuity of 6/6.

(b) **For Female:-**

(i) Age : Minimum 18 Maximum 25 years.
(ii) Height : Minimum 5 feet
(iii) Weight : As per BMI
(iv) Education qualification : Class X/VTI
(v) Martial status : Single
(vi) No prominent unnatural marks (Tattoo of any kind) on any parts of the body that will have to be exposed when in uniform.
(vii) No body piercing on any part of the body.
(viii) No knock-knee
(ix) No hearing impairment
(x) Visual acuity of 6/6.

6. Documents required :-

(a) Security Clearance Certificate,
(b) Copy of Citizenship Card.
(c) 02 copies of passport size photographs.
(d) Copy of CID cards of both the parents.
(e) Parental consent letter/undertaking
(f) NOC from parent organization if employed/monks.
(g) School leaving certificate, mark sheet and other relevant certificates **for female candidates** only.

7. For further clarification/query contact **Focal Officer** of the respective Recruitment centres.

Massive Hailstone damage to Tsirang's chillies, vegetables and fruits

Monica Rai/*Thimphu*

To the astonishment of many across the nation, a heavy hailstone on 10 April in Tsirang made news, but , the farmers in Tsirang wept in dismay due to the agricultural loss of their produce to the hailstone.

Beda Moni Chamlagai, Kilkhortang Gup, said, "Every crop and vegetable is damaged, such as oranges, cabbages, cauliflowers, and chillies, which were blossoming and had leaves, and all of it is now gone. The maximum impact was on cash crops such as oranges and local and Indian chillies."

"Currently, we are collecting data on to what extent everybody has incurred losses, and I can tell it is a huge loss for everybody," he added.

There are six gewogs affected the worst by the heavy hailstone, namely Gosarling Gewog, Rangthaling Gewog, Kilkhorthang Gewog, and Tsholingkhar Gewog, followed by Semjong Gewog and Doonglagang Gewog, which were partially affected.

"This is one of the heaviest hailstones in our dzongkhag. I don't think we will be able to revive the lost vegetables and crops. The hailstone was only present for one to two hours during the day, but it blanketed everything on its path with five to six centimetres of snow-thick hailstone," the Gup said.

Kilkhorthang resident Sukman Lama said, "Yes, there is significant devastation. Every crop in our village, including maize and vegetables, is ruined. Our village's maize was just recently sown and it was in a growth stage; it is now completely gone. The fruit trees that were provided to us during the million fruit tree plantations were the next to sustain damage, after the surrounding vegetation. Everything has vanished."

He said, "Nothing can be replanted now that it is off season, and every village in our gewog has incurred losses, except for those that were inside the greenhouse."

He said that for now, people seem to have no plans since they are all saddened by the loss incurred.

"Everybody is incurring a loss of thirty, forty thousand or up to hundred thousand. We were supposed to get that back at the end of the season during the time of harvest, and today, we have nothing. Every one of us here is a farmer and heavily dependent on farming for our expenses. We are at a loss without a backup plan," he said.

Diliram, a father to three kids, said, "I have school-going kids; I have to pay for their monthly expenses and sustain our livelihood. If I look at my field, everything I owned and worked hard for is gone and smashed. I cannot revive it."

"It will be a difficult time for us now," he added.

Currently, the gups of the affected gewogs said that the villagers are made out to fill out forms on how many losses have been caused and damaged. The gups are compiling the reports, which will be sent out to the Dzongkhag Administration Office soon.

The Gups share the sentiments of the villagers, expecting to be compensated in the form of incentives for major cash crops amounting to up to a hundred thousand, more or less.

On the other hand, the agriculture extension officer said that it is just an assessment from the Dzongkhag disaster management to see the extent of the damage, and he does not know anything about whether the farmers will be compensated or not.

MoESD implements thorough screening criteria for contract teacher selection

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

The Ministry of Education and Skills Development (MoESD) announced the list of selected candidates for Resigned Teachers on Contract slots.

While many of the selected teachers will teach general subjects, however, there are more candidates for teaching English language compared to other teaching positions.

Out of the total 521 applicants, 100 have been selected based on the criteria set by MoESD.

To uphold educational standards and ensure the quality of instruction, MoESD has introduced a precise set of criteria for the selection of new teachers.

The screening process thoroughly checks the teachers' records to ensure dedication and professionalism, emphasizing the ministry's commitment to maintaining high standards among the selected candidates.

Moreover, MoESD has taken a strong standpoint on the exclusion of teachers with termination or disciplinary issues. This aspect of the criteria underscores the importance placed on facilitating a positive work environment and also helps to question past incidents and policies surrounding employee behavior.

In addition, the criteria notably disregard teachers who left the system long ago, acknowledging the changes in the education curriculum thus, teaching staff with current educational standards were selected.

According to the Ministry's statement, the position level of selected teachers will now be fixed to the last position held before separation from the civil service. This is intended to provide clarity and consistency in determining the roles and responsibilities of recruited teachers, aligning them with their previous experience within the civil service framework.

Furthermore, the basic pay for selected candidates will be set at the minimum or starting basic pay of their respective position levels before separation. In addition to the basic pay, selected teachers "... will receive a flat 35% teaching allowance applied to their basic salary."

MoESD also informed that the selected teachers will be offered contracts lasting either two years or until they reach the age at which they are eligible for pension benefits, whichever comes first.

Moreover, the candidates should be aware that they will undergo a mandatory drug test as per the Bhutan Civil Service Rules (BCSR) of 2023 to maintain a safe and healthy work environment for both educators and students.

This mandatory drug test also implies that selected candidates may not retain their positions if they test positive.

MoESD also tried to recruit from the graduate pool of 2023, however, the shortage persists due to a combination of factors, including a lack of applicants and there aren't enough teachers for the required subjects.

Additionally, with RCSC's approval to recruit 600 contract teachers and resigned teachers, the ministry is hopeful that this could help address teacher attrition. MoESD is cautious, stating that this gap may not be filled as more teachers continue to resign.

The ministry also excluded the private school teachers as they have the opportunity to apply for contract teaching positions in the districts and thromdes.

Despite efforts to recruit more teachers, the issue of teachers leaving their jobs remains.

cont. from pg 01

Times get much tougher for Bhutanese students in Australia

got a job, but was only paid AUD 16 per hour which is like an exploitation as it comes to around AUD 400 per week when the sister's weekly rent portion, itself, is around AUD 300.

Pema sad she is keenly aware that she and her sister are being exploited, but they have no option.

Pema said that given the limited pay, and to survive, there are those who work beyond the 24 hours per week but this is a huge risk as immigration officials can track via various ways, like tax data and even bank data.

"Recently there was a case where a Bhutanese student on completing his course applied for a TR visa which he got, but after 8 days the immigration officials cancelled his visa and sent him back to Bhutan saying he had earned enough after checking his bank account," said Pema.

The officials were able to figure out that he had worked beyond his 24-hour limit per week while he was a student.

Fear has spread among the Bhutanese student community upon hearing about this case.

However, there are those driven to desperation who work beyond the 24 hours. Pema said that the white Australians don't hire such student workers due to fear of the law, but is usually the Asian employers like Vietnamese, Chinese and Filipinos who hire such students and pay them below the minimum wage, and usually in cash.

Students have to take lower wages as they cannot complain, as they, themselves, are not within the law.

Another student, Deki (name changed), said, "The job situation hasn't improved. Being a student makes it extremely difficult to get jobs due to working hour restrictions. Even some of my friends, who are student dependents with full working rights, are still unemployed."

She further added, "They apply for jobs through online job portals and applications, and some even walk into restaurants, offices, etc., but they only get responses that indicate they will call if they need manpower. Some are left unemployed for more than three months, and some for six months. It's all about recommendations. However, recommendations are no longer working due to an overwhelming number of applicants."

Deki said that for now, she is working at a warehouse with a minimum shift of one to two days, which does not even add up to 24 hours per week.

As for the nature of jobs the students are doing, Pema said many do Door Dash which is food delivery, as even Uber is difficult to get now since only a certain number of registrations are accepted.

However, to even do a Door Dash, Pema said that Bhutanese end up spending AUD 7,000 plus in buying second hand cars.

Pema said it has been nine months for her in Australia and she got a huge culture shock initially with her unable to find work for two months. She said that online job portals don't work anymore, given the number of applicants and limited jobs, and so she had to do a lot of walk ins to secure her job.

Pema said that many of the Bhutanese youth are working as kitchen hands and also do vegetable and meat packing work. They can do this only because they had come with a mindset from Bhutan to be ready to do any job to make money.

Pema said apart from her university, she even took an aged care course but none of the 20 plus Bhutanese students in her class have been placed, though she also heard it takes time to get these jobs.

She said that Bhutanese who came earlier and have longer work hours are in aged care and disability care.

Living expenses

Pema said that it is impossible for a student to work the 24 hours per week and pay rent and for food and also save for university fees.

Giving her own example, Pema said she gets paid better than her sister and makes around AUD 600 a week working the legal 24 hours.

However, she has to pay AUD 200 as her share of the rent and with food, transport and other bills to pay she cannot save for her university fees, forget about saving for back home.

Pema said the only way she can afford her situation is due to her partner who has agreed to bear 70 percent of the fees.

Pema said the only hope for students like her is that once they complete the course they can get a two years TR visa, and use that time to earn and save money, but given the many visa changes happening, she is not even certain about that anymore.

Pema advised that it is easier for a husband and wife couple, as one can work full time and there is better understanding and they can even save.

She said single people should not even come, as it will be impossible for them to work and sustain on the minimal income.

Expensive Housing

Pema said that apart from work, housing is still a major issue. She said that when people reach Australia, they cannot even contact their people as people are busy and have different timings.

Pema is living in a house with 7 to 8 people, and they pay AUD 200 each.

Deki said, "The housing issue is still the same. People continue to search for houses, and housing rentals remain too high. When you apply for a property through an agent, they ask for your rental history, which is difficult for a newcomer because individuals are unable to provide proof of their previous leasing." Deki said she and her husband lived in a combined house or sharing with a Bhutanese friendfor over 8 months before considering leaving due to the distance between their job stations.

"We applied and went to inspect about 20 properties, but we were unsuccessful. But when we got the house, it was a semi-detached duplex house with five rooms and the weekly rent was AUD 600 per week, which was too costly and big for a couple, but we had no other options and had to accept it. However, once our lease ends, we are planning on moving into a smaller property, which will be easier for us because we will have a rental history to offer the agent when we apply," she added.

Deki said people charge between AUD 225 and 250 per week for a single accommodation in shared households, and it is too costly for a single person.

Dr Sonam Tenzin said that rent has effectively doubled and even tripled in some cases compared to the COVID times. A two-bedroom apartment that was once AUD 280 per week is now AUD 510 or more.

Children

When it comes to children, Pema said that normally young couples leave their children and come, but they miss them a lot, suffer emotional breakdowns and she has friends who do hours of live call chat. The parents later get the children to join them in Australia, and there are also cases of people moving with their children despite the difficulties, just to be close to their children.

Pema who has a child left behind in Bhutan is thinking of bringing him there once she finishes her course and can start earning better.

The white-collar jobs and business owners

While most Bhutanese in Australia are fresh off the boat and mainly do blue collar jobs, there is also a significant number of them who went to Australia earlier doing white collar jobs due to better qualifications and skills and experience. There are also Bhutanese who own their own businesses.

One such person is Dr Sonam Tenzin (real name) who owns an education consultancy business apart from handling other projects, and he had also served as the President of the ABPI association and is a continuing board member.

Sonam worked in the Department of IT and Telecom in Bhutan, and in 2013 he finished his Masters in IT from Murdoch University, and he came back to Bhutan and worked for 4 years after which he did his PhD in IT in Murdoch University and got a job in an IT Consultancy, and over the years, he handled several major projects before establishing his own businesses.

Dr Sonam represents the earlier and also current wave of well qualified and skilled Bhutanese. He said that the image back home is that all Bhutanese in Australia are doing blue collar work, but he said there are also many working as engineers, doctors, nurses, operation managers, customer service managers, consultants, etc., as they move up the ladder.

He said there are many Bhutanese working in aged and disability care sector. He said there are around 50 to 60 Bhutanese business owners in Perth, running restaurants to shops.

He said there are Bhutanese moving to Australia because even with the current job market in Australia, it is still easier to find a job in Australia than in Bhutan. He said for those bent on heading to Australia, it is important to upskill and also have the right attitude and right connections. He also advises students to follow the rule of the land, in terms of staying within the working hours.

Coming back?

When asked if people are planning to come back with tougher visa conditions, Pema said that there is no talk of going back, and even for those who have been there for a while, they are looking at various ways to extend their stay.

Some are taking technical courses that are in the skills list, while others who cannot, are taking nursing courses which is also in need.

She said she has a friend who is talking about going to Canada if his visa is not extended in Australia, but there is no talk about going to Bhutan.

Deki said, "I haven't seen anyone going back, but I've

cont. on pg 11

cont. from pg 10

Times get much tougher for Bhutanese students in Australia

heard rumours that individuals are returning due to difficulties they are experiencing here."

Dr Sonam said that only very few number are going back, but the majority are staying back in Australia.

When asked if Bhutanese will come back, Dr Sonam said that people in his generation have a huge attachment to Bhutan and want to invest and contribute back to Bhutan, but they also need an avenue with the right policies in Bhutan.

He said he would like to open a branch of his company in Bhutan, but the regulations are not friendly, with one example being that his branch office in Bhutan cannot have the same name as in Australia.

He said the environment and policies in Bhutan are not conducive, and he, as a former government official, did not see it but he can now see the issues on the other side.

He said older Bhutanese may come back at one point to avoid being in old age homes, but the same cannot be said for the younger generation who may want to stay back in Australia.

He said there are already more than 1,000 Bhutanese who have got PR.

Dr Sonam also acknowledged that there are Bhutanese who are selling their assets in Bhutan and moving the money to Australia to invest.

He said even for his generation, they may want to go back, but making an income and their kids' education hold them back, and they have to see the education of the kids through after which the kids get married, and they may have to stay back looking after their grandkids.

cont. from pg 01

Smugglers use innovative new techniques to smuggle gold via Bhutan

phishing being Indians who offer some sort of package to anybody who is willing to visit Bhutan.

The recent Thai national involved in attempting to smuggle gold powder from Bangkok, Thailand into Bhutan, was a college student.

He was offered a package of three days to stay in Bhutan. First day land in Paro, go to Thimphu for sightseeing, next day go to Taktsang and third day they return by Jaigoan to India.

All the expenses are covered by the main smuggler.

Also, RBP shared that looking at the trend, Bhutan is just a route because the gold doesn't stay here.

Further, the strategy of smuggling gold is also changing. As in the past, the smugglers or carriers used to carry gold powder and bars. However, now the gold paste is painted on to the inner layer of clothes which are not removable and are not easily detected.

In the recent gold bust, the suspects concealed the gold in their bodies.

RBP apprehended a Thai national on 10 March 2024 following a tip-off suggesting his involvement in attempting to smuggle gold powder from Bangkok, Thailand into Bhutan.

He was arrested from a hotel in Paro town with more than 3kg of gold powder cello taped and concealed in his pants.

As per sources on 8 March 2024, two Indians were intercepted attempting to smuggle 2.5 kg of gold powder which were found concealed inside of their jean pants that they were wearing.

They were traveling from Bangkok to Paro and planned to exit Bhutan via road to Phuentsholing and then to Jaigoan, India.

Also, on 3 March 2024 an Indian national was apprehended with 140 grams of gold piece that was found concealed in the jacket pocket he was wearing. He was traveling from Bangkok to Paro and planned to exit Bhutan via Jaigoan.

In both the instances, the suspects were identified as high-risk passengers while carrying out the daily passenger profiling conducted by a dedicated team of customs officials. They were then closely monitored, their belongings scanned through X-ray machine and questioned by the field customs officials.

Nothing was detected through normal course of action. However, since the suspects displayed change in their behavioral pattern, their body were thoroughly frisked by customs officials, and in the process intercepted the concealed gold.

In Bhutan, gold is sold from the Duty-Free outlets only.

It was known that as a duty-free baggage allowance, a Bhutanese national and foreigners above the age of 15 years residing in Bhutan and travelling by air and returning to the country is entitled to bring in gold, in any form including in jewelry, up to 50 grams.

However, aircrew and foreigners including tourist are not entitled to bring in gold under baggage allowance.

Nevertheless, a person can import gold in any quantity and in any form including jewelry beyond its baggage allowance if he or she possesses import permit obtained from Royal Monetary Authority of Bhutan and declares to customs at the point of entry into Bhutan.

As far as Paro International Airport is concerned, the common route is from Bangkok to Paro.

While asking how are customs and law enforcement working on the preventive front of such illegal gold smuggling across the borders, the Department of Revenue and Customs (DRC), Ministry of Finance shared that they do not have access or hold any participation to any preventive activities being initiated across border since it is beyond the jurisdiction of the department.

DRC said that the gold smugglers perceive the Bhutan customs enforcement capacity is not competent enough to apprehend smugglers, and that it is easy to pass through.

However, over the period of time, the customs enforcement capacity has been strengthened in terms of equipment used, number of manpower deployed, and methods and techniques used to deal with illicit trade.

DRC said that they cannot confirm with certainty, whether the smugglers play the role of carrier and are paid by someone. However, upon interrogation, most of the smugglers declare themselves as the carrier.

RBP shared that the individuals will be charged for smuggling.

As per the Penal Code of Bhutan, a defendant shall be guilty of the offence of smuggling, if the defendant secretly and illegally imports or exports the restricted and prohibited goods or substances including animal parts.

The offence of smuggling shall be a value-based sentencing.

cont. from pg 01

Proposal to give SDF free MICE tourism for 7 days and 6 nights

Apart from extending the MICE period the new proposal is also to allow the MICE participants some time to enjoy Bhutan and hence make it a little more flexible.

The idea is also that MICE can only be organized through tour operators and hotels.

Earlier, the minimum group size to qualify as a MICE event was seven participants.

The SDF waiver cannot be extended to spouse or family members of MICE participants.

The MICE event can happen any time of the year so there is no blackout dates.

MICE SDF waiver must be applied at least one month before the event.

Only certain events that fall within the category of Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibitions will be eligible for the SDF waiver.

A summary of the event, including the outcomes and photographs, must be submitted by the applicant to the Department of Tourism within one month of the departure date of the guests.

The Tourism Department had said that globally, the MICE market is one of the highest revenue contributors to the tourism industry with its value accounted for around USD 916 billion and it is projected to reach USD 1,439 billion in 2025.

MICE tourism is very important for Bhutan with its impact touching all levels of the tourism value chain, especially supporting the MICE businesses and venues of Bhutan.

The tale of Bhutan's Romeo and Juliet to go international

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

The renowned story of Bhutan's Romeo and Juliet, Gasa Lami Singye and Changyul Boom Galam has been told and retold over generations, and also made into several movies by the Bhutanese film industry.

The story is believed to take place around the 17th century. Galem was a beautiful woman and the daughter of a wealthy farmer in Punakha who used to frequent Puna Dashitsawa, which was the main market of Punakha.

Singye was an attendant of the Deb (Chieftain) of Punakha whose centre of power and administration was the Punakha Dzong.

The duo had fallen in love and used to meet secretly. The Deb had noticed the extraordinary beauty of Galem and wanted to marry her, so he instructed his assistants to make the necessary arrangements.

Realizing the existing deep relationship between Galem and Singye, Singye was sent to serve the Lam of the monastic body of Gasa, the district north of Punakha..

Galem's parents were overjoyed with the Deb's proposed marriage to Galem. However, Galem did not agree and confessed her relationship with Singye, whereby she was already carrying his child.

This enraged her parents who threw her out of her house. Galem was forced to live alone on the bank of the Mochu and singing out to the rare travelers and sent a message to Singye in Gasa informing of her difficulty.

A passerby, moved by her predicament, volunteered to go to Gasa although his destination was only Goenshari.

When Singye received the news, he immediately rushed to Punakha, only to find that Galem had passed away and was already on her funeral pyre.

Legend says that the funeral pyre would not burn until the arrival of Singye, who could not bear this site, and jumped on the funeral pyre which engulfed both of them immediately.

The tragic love story in the mould of "Romeo and Juliet" has become popular by the day with many people interested to see the real site of the story.

Galem's house is a major attraction in Punakha, and it is to be renovated at the earliest, to keep the legend of Gasa Lamai Singye and Changyul Boom Galem alive, and further enrich the tradition and culture of Punakha.

The current decendents of Galem have moved out to newly built houses nearby.

Holding such significant connection with every Bhutanese, the Home and Cultural Affairs Minister Tshering said that the ministry has almost secured the drawing estimated budget fund which comes to Nu 17.6 million (mn) for the renovation of Changyuel Bum Galem's ancestral house in Punakha.

He said that as Galem's house is historically important, the ministry have almost finalized the design of the house.

He said, "When we say design, it's not that we are going to build it from the base. Rather we will be renovating cracks on the wall. Most importantly we need to renovate the roof, fix the cracks and also come up with the footpaths and streetlights outside, which are almost ready."

The government will renovate and hand it over to the descendants. An MoU will be signed where the owners will take care of the structures and demolishment of the property will be prohibited.

The amount will be provided by a former German diplomat.

The former German diplomat, Harald Nestroy, shared that Germany's Foreign Ministry and "Pro Bhutan" a non-profit German philanthropic NGO will be funding about Nu 11 mn for the restoration of Galem's ancestral house.

Upon asking the reason for the funding, he said, "Our personal attachment to the unique Kingdom of Bhutan and its people, culture, history, and the beauty of this last intact Buddhist Himalaya country, is the reason. We support the Bhutanese people through the RGoB, mainly in the fields and in closest cooperation with the relevant ministry, planning, constructing and financing large projects."

The preparation of the project for restoration of Bum Galem's Heritage House including the establishment of a public museum in the restored building is in the very last stage.

MoHA said that the finalizing and signing of the "Project Agreement" between the RGoB and "Pro Bhutan, Germany" as the basis for the release of funds will be done latest by 15 April, 2024.

The financial contribution of "Pro Bhutan, Germany" for the Restoration shall cover the design, planning and supervision. It will also take care of the restoration of building, site development and landscaping, and thee establishment of the museum inside the building. Also, ancillary infrastructure plan will be done by the dzongkhag administration.

Along with it, RGoB has so far listed 16 unique traditional structures which will require renovation.

The house of Galem dates back to Zhabdrung's time and the old traditions are still practiced today like offering Soelthap (reception offering) to Goendrap (local deity) and it is also a stop when Kabji pazaps bring the tshendhar (fringed warrior banner) of Gayngyen Jakpa Melen (guardian deity of Thimphu) from Pangrizampa to the Dzong.

The male descendants of Galem still play an active role in the above functions.

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